

monikers. The problem is there are just too many of them. In fact, one of the biggest misdeeds the industry regularly perpetrates is its inability to get together and finalise a set of standards for the consumers. This slows down the adoption of the technology as a whole, and at the same time it also isolates users from one another.

Instead of one or two simple choices, consumers are now faced with a deluge of five competing formats, all of which come with confusingly similar names. You have DVD-RAM, DVD-RW, DVD+RW, DVD-R and finally, DVD+R. Each format has its own group of supporting manufacturers, and all of them are extremely busy telling you that theirs will be the *de facto* standard in the end. In the computing world, usually only one format from many survives—the others, after some noise, silently pass away.

DVD-RAM was the first recordable DVD format to hit the scene. If you've ever used a floppy disk, you'll get the idea of how DVD-RAM works. Though storing data on a DVD-RAM drive is a totally different process from, say, a hard disk or

Comparing Features: DVD and CD Writers					
	DVD-R	DVD-RW	DVD-RAM	DVD+RW	CD-RW
Maximum storage space	9.4 GB	4.7 GB	9.4 GB	4.7 GB	800 MB
Cost per disc (in Rs)*	1.7 GB @ 950 9.4 GB @ 1,700	1,800	1.7 GB @ 2,000 9.4 GB @ 3,100	2,000	CD-R @ 20 CD-RW @ 150
Maximum writing speeds	2.77 MBps (2x)	1.39 MBps (1x)	2.77 MBps (2x)	3.2 MBps (2.4x)	3.51 MBps (24x)
Average cost per MB*	20 paise	37 paise	40 paise	30 paise	3 paise (CD-R) 70 paise (CD-RW)
Cost for writer (in Rs)*	25,000	25,000	32,000	35,000	7,000 to 12,000
*Prices/costs listed are approximate					

it has some pretty strong voices to back it up. Dell, Compaq and Philips are just a few of the heavyweights. When you take a look at what DVD+RW can do, it makes you wonder why and how DVD-RW left these features out in the first place. For instance, DVD+RW has the ability to write to media similar to how DVD-RAM and floppy disks do. Also, you can use the same disc on your PC to read data files and on a standalone player to playback any video on that disc. Drag-and-drop support is another plus point of this format.

// A DVD disc packs 4.7 GB on a single side, burns four times as fast as CD-RW, and is very versatile //

floppy disk, the computer logically treats it as such. But where this format shoots itself in the foot is in the domain of acceptance. Thanks to its proprietary cartridge casing, compatibility of DVD-RAM has taken a nosedive. The exodus has already begun. Apple and Sony, once strong advocates of DVD-RAM, have stopped promoting it even though they still sell it. We spoke to vendors who sell DVD-RAM drives. A large share of them predict a short shelf life for the format in the face of DVD-R, DVD-RW, and its next iteration, DVD+RW.

Looking at it broadly, both DVD-R and DVD-RW closely resemble the workings of the CD-R and CD-RW formats before them, only that they store a lot more. The maximum holding capacity of these formats is 9.4 GB and 4.7 GB for DVD-R and DVD-RW respectively, while each can boast of 80 to 90 per cent compatibility with DVD players.

For the time being, DVD-R/RW will enjoy widespread acceptance. But now with DVD+R and DVD+RW on the market, that scenario is certain to change.

Two positive reasons to shift
DVD+RW has emerged as the alternative for DVD-RW as

But perhaps one of the most impressive features of DVD+RW is its ability to resume an interrupted writing session from where it left off.

DVD+RW even writes faster than DVD-RW—2.4 times as fast on rewritable media. On the single write types, it still outruns DVD-RW by operating at 2.4x as opposed to 2x for DVD-RW. As for DVD+R, it is more of a single-write extension of the DVD+RW format. At best, DVD+R could simply be a more cost-effective media for those who want DVD+RW drives but really don't have a need to rewrite any discs.

Room for only one

Wading through this crowd of formats, it's pretty clear that this battle boils down to two sides, the 'minuses' versus the 'pluses'. The DVD-R/RW formats, though widely accepted today, are facing the heat from two new and improved formats, DVD+R and DVD+RW. The latter combines the best features of earlier formats such as random access writing, compatibility with various DVD players, and more importantly, it is easier to use. Since DVD+RW is the newest format to emerge in this already crowded field, the drives and media may cost slightly more than other formats for the time being. But once a critical mass of consumers has been reached, prices will plummet resulting in a boon for storage-savvy consumers.

Till then, we'll have to wait with our CD-Rs. But not for long as the storage revolution has begun. All we have to do now is hasten the adoption process. With a *little* help from companies, of course. ■

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